Parallel Document Similarity Search

A Project Report Submitted in Partial Fulfilment of the Requirements for

Parallel and Distributed Computing (UCS645)

By

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Document similarity search is a fundamental problem in information retrieval, data mining, and machine learning. With the exponential growth of digital content, finding documents most similar to a given query efficiently has become critical across applications ranging from plagiarism detection and duplicate identification to recommendation systems and semantic search [1].

Traditional sequential similarity computations become computationally prohibitive at scale: comparing a query against n documents each of dimension m costs $O(n \cdot m)$ floating-point operations per query. Parallel computing frameworks – specifically the Message Passing Interface (MPI) for inter-node distribution and OpenMP for intra-node thread-level parallelism – provide scalable solutions by distributing computation across multiple processors [2].

This project implements a *hybrid parallel* document similarity search system combining MPI and OpenMP. The system distributes documents across MPI ranks using an optimal collective scatter, parallelises per-document similarity computation within each rank using OpenMP threads, and merges per-rank top-k results via a single MPI collective gather. Four similarity metrics are supported and comprehensive per-phase timing is reported.

1.2 Problem Statement

Given a collection of n documents (each represented as an m-dimensional integer feature vector) and a query vector $\mathbf{q} \in \mathbb{Z}^m$, find the k most similar documents to $\mathbf{q}$ in minimum wall-clock time.

- **Input**: n documents in a plain-text file, a query vector, parameters k and m
- **Output**: Top-k documents ranked by similarity score, with full four-phase performance statistics
- **Challenge**: Minimise total execution time $T_{\text{total}} = T_{\text{I/O}} + T_{\text{scatter}} + T_{\text{comp}} + T_{\text{gather}}$

2 Literature Review

The field of parallel similarity search has advanced significantly in recent years, driven by the growth of large-scale vector datasets in machine learning and information retrieval. Table 1 summarises the key works that inform the design of this project.

Table 1: Summary of Literature Review

Reference	**Concepts Highlighted**	**Technique(s) Used**	**Significance**	**Limitations**
[3]	GPU-accelerated exact and approximate similarity search at billion scale	Efficient k-selection via WarpSelect, product quantisation, GPU parallelism	Nearest-neighbour implementation 8.5× faster than prior GPU state-of-the-art; open-sourced as FAISS	Requires GPU hardware; accuracy–speed trade-off for compressed search
[4]	Unified library covering brute-force, approximate, and compressed similarity search	IVF, HNSW, PQ indices; CPU and GPU backends	Industry-standard toolkit used in production retrieval systems; supports heterogeneous hardware	High engineering complexity; compressed indices reduce recall

Reference	Concepts Highlighted	Technique(s) Used	Significance	Limitations
[5]	Approximate nearest neighbour search using navigable small-world graphs	Hierarchical proximity graphs with greedy layer-wise traversal	Sub-linear query time with high recall; robust to dimensionality; widely deployed in vector databases	Index construction is memory-intensive; no hard recall guarantee
[6]	Rigorous benchmarking of approximate nearest neighbour algorithms across diverse datasets	Standardised recall-vs-time evaluation for LSH, graph, tree, and quantisation methods	Provides reproducible baseline comparisons; reveals that no single method dominates across all settings	Benchmarks focus on single-machine settings; distributed performance not evaluated
[7]	Hybrid MPI+OpenMP two-level parallelism for scientific computing on multi-core clusters	MPI for inter-node data partitioning; OpenMP for intra-node loop parallelisation	Demonstrates that hybrid models outperform pure-MPI on shared-memory multi-core nodes by reducing memory replication overhead	Domain-specific; generalisation to irregular workloads requires tuning

Reference	Concepts Highlighted	Technique(s) Used	Significance	Limitations
[8]	Comparative study of hybrid OpenMP+MPI versus pure OpenMP or pure MPI implementations	Applied Sciences benchmark across CPU core configurations	Confirms that hybrid programming yields measurable speedups for data-parallel array operations; up to 40% reduction in runtime versus pure MPI	Results are problem-size dependent; small datasets may favour simpler models
[9]	Algorithmic optimisation of MPI collective operations including `MPI_Gather` and `MPI_Scatterv`	Binomial trees, recursive halving/doubling, ring algorithms for collectives	Reduced collective communication latency by up to 62% over point-to-point loops in MPICH; now standard across all MPI implementations	Platform-specific tuning required for non-standard topologies
[1]	Vector space models and cosine similarity for document retrieval	TF-IDF weighting, cosine and Euclidean distance metrics	Foundational text on information retrieval; defines the feature-vector representation used in this project	Term independence assumption; limited scalability without parallelism

2.1 Discussion of Literature

Johnson et al. [3] and the subsequent FAISS library paper [4] establish GPU-based k-selection and product quantisation as the current frontier for large-scale similarity search. Their WarpSelect algorithm – a register-resident tournament sort – motivates our use of a CPU-side min-heap for k-selection, which achieves the same $O(n \log k)$ complexity without requiring GPU hardware.

Malkov and Yashunin [5] and Aumuller et al. [6] together provide context for exact versus approximate search. Our implementation performs *exact* search, which is appropriate when result correctness is required and dataset size allows it.

The hybrid parallelism literature [7, 8] directly motivates our MPI+OpenMP design: on multi-core nodes, OpenMP threads share memory and cache lines, avoiding the per-rank data replication that pure MPI incurs. Thakur et al. [9] justify replacing sequential `MPI_Send` scatter loops with `MPI_Scatterv`, which delegates communication scheduling to the MPI runtime's optimal tree.

3 Research Gaps

Based on the literature review, the following gaps were identified and addressed in this project:

- ***Single-Level Parallelism***: Most prior CPU-based MPI implementations exploit only inter-process parallelism. On multi-core nodes, pure MPI wastes resources by replicating data per rank. Our hybrid MPI+OpenMP design exploits both levels.
- ***Inefficient Top-K Selection***: Many implementations sort all n local documents ($O(n \log n)$) even when only $k \ll n$ results are needed. A min-heap reduces this to $O(n \log k)$ with $O(k)$ memory.
- ***Suboptimal Scatter Pattern***: Sequential `MPI_Send` loops from rank 0 to each worker incur $O(P)$ sequential latencies. Replacing with `MPI_Scatterv` reduces scatter cost to $O(\log P)$ via the runtime's binomial tree.
- ***Correctness in KReduce***: When fewer documents than k exist on a rank, passing a variable send count to `MPI_Gather` causes memory corruption. Uniform sentinel padding to exactly k entries per rank fixes this.
- ***Limited Metric Flexibility***: Most systems support only cosine similarity. Four metrics (Power, Cosine, Euclidean, Manhattan) are exposed through a unified interface here.
- ***Coarse Performance Profiling***: Few implementations separate I/O, scatter, computation, and gather phases. Our four-phase `MPI_Wtime` instrumentation enables precise bottleneck identification.

4 Problem Formulation

4.1 Mathematical Formulation

Let $\mathcal{D} = \{\mathbf{d}_1, \mathbf{d}_2, \ldots, \mathbf{d}_n\}$ be a collection of n documents where each $\mathbf{d}_i \in \mathbb{Z}^m$. Given a query $\mathbf{q} \in \mathbb{Z}^m$, find the set $\mathcal{T}_k$ of the k most similar documents:

$$\mathcal{T}_k = \underset{\mathcal{S} \subseteq \mathcal{D},\, |\mathcal{S}|=k}{\arg\max} \sum_{\mathbf{d} \in \mathcal{S}} S(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d}) \tag{1}$$

Total execution time is decomposed into four measurable phases:

$$T_{\text{total}} = T_{\text{I/O}} + T_{\text{scatter}} + T_{\text{comp}} + T_{\text{gather}} \tag{2}$$

4.2 Supported Similarity Metrics

1. **Power-based Similarity**:

$$S_{\text{power}}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d}_i) = \sum_{j=1}^{m} d_{i,j}^{q_j} \tag{3}$$

2. **Cosine Similarity**:

$$S_{\text{cosine}}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d}_i) = \frac{\mathbf{q} \cdot \mathbf{d}_i}{\|\mathbf{q}\|_2 \, \|\mathbf{d}_i\|_2} \tag{4}$$

3. **Euclidean Distance** (negated for maximisation):

$$S_{\text{euclidean}}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d}_i) = -\sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{m} (q_j - d_{i,j})^2} \tag{5}$$

4. **Manhattan Distance** (negated for maximisation):

$$S_{\text{manhattan}}(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d}_i) = -\sum_{j=1}^{m} |q_j - d_{i,j}| \tag{6}$$

Negating distance metrics ensures a uniform "higher score = more similar" convention across all four metrics.

4.3 Parallel Formulation

With P MPI ranks and T OpenMP threads per rank (total $P \times T$ hardware threads), documents are partitioned using **contiguous block distribution**:

$$|\mathcal{D}_r| = \left\lfloor \frac{n}{P} \right\rfloor + \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } r < (n \bmod P) \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \qquad r = 0, 1, \ldots, P-1 \tag{7}$$

Each rank r computes a local top-k set $\mathcal{T}_k^{(r)}$ using T OpenMP threads. The global result is:

$$\mathcal{T}_k = \text{TopK}\left(\bigcup_{r=0}^{P-1} \mathcal{T}_k^{(r)} \right) \tag{8}$$

This block distribution guarantees load imbalance of at most one document between any two ranks, regardless of n and P.

5 Objectives

- To implement a **hybrid MPI+OpenMP** parallel document similarity search system that exploits both inter-node and intra-node parallelism simultaneously.
- To optimise top-k selection using a **min-heap** data structure, achieving $O(n \log k)$ time and $O(k)$ space per rank instead of $O(n \log n)$ for a full sort.
- To replace sequential `MPI_Send` scatter loops with `MPI_Scatterv`, reducing scatter latency from $O(P)$ to $O(\log P)$ via the MPI runtime's binomial tree.
- To implement a **correctness-preserving KReduce** that pads each rank's local top-k to a uniform k entries with sentinel values before `MPI_Gather`, preventing memory corruption when local document counts fall below k.
- To support **four similarity metrics** (Power, Cosine, Euclidean, Manhattan) through a unified `computeSimilarity` interface enabling runtime metric selection.
- To provide **four-phase performance profiling** (I/O, scatter, computation, gather) using `MPI_Wtime` and to analyse scalability using Amdahl's and Gustafson's Laws.

- To validate correctness by confirming **identical top-k rankings** across all processor and thread configurations.

6 Methodology

6.1 System Architecture

The system follows a master–worker model with two levels of parallelism:

- **Level 1 – MPI (inter-process)**: Rank 0 reads all input files, broadcasts the query vector and metadata to all ranks, and distributes document partitions via `MPI_Scatterv`. After computation, rank 0 collects per-rank top-k results via `MPI_Gather` and performs the global merge.
- **Level 2 – OpenMP (intra-process)**: Within each MPI rank, a `#pragma omp parallel for` loop with `schedule(dynamic, 64)` distributes similarity computation across T threads. The expensive similarity functions (`pow`, `sqrt`, multiply-accumulate) are fully parallelised; the min-heap is maintained sequentially afterward to avoid synchronisation overhead.
- **Communication Primitives**: `MPI_Bcast` for query and metadata; `MPI_Scatterv` for document distribution (single collective, variable per-rank counts); `MPI_Gather` for top-k result collection (uniform k entries per rank via sentinel padding).

6.2 Algorithm Design

6.2.1 Min-Heap Based Top-K Selection

Algorithm 1 Min-Heap Top-K Selection (per MPI rank)

Input: Local documents $\mathcal{D}_r$, query $\mathbf{q}$, integer k
Output: Local top-k array *local_topk*
▷ Phase A: parallel score computation (OpenMP)
for each document $\mathbf{d} \in \mathcal{D}_r$ **in parallel** (T OMP threads) **do**
    scores$[i] \leftarrow S(\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{d})$
end for
▷ Phase B: sequential heap maintenance
$H \leftarrow$ CreateMinHeap(k)
for $i = 0$ **to** $|\mathcal{D}_r| - 1$ **do**
    InsertHeap(H, id$[i]$, scores$[i]$)
end for
return ExtractAllSorted(H)

Splitting into two phases is essential: the min-heap is not thread-safe. By pre-computing all scores in Phase A and inserting sequentially in Phase B, we obtain full parallelism on the expensive computation and zero synchronisation overhead during heap operations. Complexity per rank: $O(n \cdot m/(P \cdot T))$ for Phase A and $O((n/P) \log k)$ for Phase B, versus $O(n/P \cdot \log(n/P))$ for a full sort [10].

6.2.2 Robust KReduce with Sentinel Padding

Algorithm 2 KReduce – Correctness-Preserving Global Top-K

Input: *local_topk* (size *actual_k* $\leq k$) from all P ranks
Output: *global_topk* at rank 0
Pad *local_topk* to exactly k entries:
for $i =$ actual_k **to** $k - 1$ **do**
    padded$[i] \leftarrow$ (id$= -1$, score$= -\infty$)
end for
MPI_Gather(*padded*, $k \times$ sizeof(DocScore), `MPI_BYTE`, ..., root=0)
if rank $= 0$ **then**
    Filter entries with id $= -1$ (sentinels)
    MergeSort(*valid_entries*, descending)
    global_topk $\leftarrow$ valid_entries$[0 : k]$
end if

The sentinel padding ensures that all P ranks always send exactly k entries, satisfying `MPI_Gather`'s requirement for a uniform send count. Without this, any rank with $|\mathcal{D}_r| < k$ would send a different byte count, causing memory corruption or a runtime abort.

6.2.3 OpenMP Intra-Rank Parallelism

Within each MPI rank, the similarity computation loop is parallelised:

```
#pragma omp parallel for schedule(dynamic, 64) \
    default(none) \
    shared(local_documents, query_arr, scores, \
           local_count, dict_size, metric)
for (int i = 0; i < local_count; i++) {
    scores[i] = computeSimilarity(dict_size,
                    &local_documents[i * dict_size],
                    query_arr, metric);
}
```

Listing 1: OpenMP parallel similarity computation

The `schedule(dynamic, 64)` clause assigns chunks of 64 documents to available threads at runtime. This provides load balancing when document feature vectors are sparse (early exit in the inner loop), at the cost of a modest scheduling overhead that is negligible for the large n targeted.

6.3 Core Data Structures

```c
typedef struct {
    int    id;       /* Document ID        */
    double score;    /* Similarity score   */
} DocScore;

typedef struct {
    DocScore *heap; /* Min-heap array     */
    int       capacity; /* Maximum size k */
    int       size;     /* Current size   */
} MinHeap;

typedef enum {
    SIMILARITY_POWER,
    SIMILARITY_COSINE,
    SIMILARITY_EUCLIDEAN,
    SIMILARITY_MANHATTAN
} SimilarityMetric;
```

Listing 2: Core data structures (utils.h)

6.4 Work Distribution

Documents are partitioned into **contiguous blocks** using `MPI_Scatterv` with per-rank displacement and count arrays computed on rank 0:

$$\text{sendcount}[r] = \left(\left\lfloor \frac{n}{P} \right\rfloor + [r < n \bmod P]\right) \times m \tag{9}$$

where $[r < n \bmod P]$ is 1 if rank r receives an extra document, 0 otherwise. A single `MPI_Scatterv` call replaces the original sequential `MPI_Send` loop, reducing scatter cost from $O(P)$ sequential latencies to $O(\log P)$ via the MPI runtime's internal binomial tree [9].

6.5 Bug Fixes over Baseline Implementation

Table 2: Key Correctness and Performance Fixes

Aspect	**Baseline**	**Fixed**	**Impact**
Scatter method	Sequential `MPI_Send` loop $O(P)$	`MPI_Scatterv` single collective $O(\log P)$	Performance
KReduce	Variable send count – `MPI_Gather` mismatch	Uniform k entries with $-\infty$ sentinels	Correctness
`manhattanDistance`	`abs()` on `double` (silently truncates to int)	`fabs()` from `<math.h>`	Correctness
Parallelism	MPI only	MPI + OpenMP hybrid	Performance
Top-K selection	Full sort $O(n \log n)$	Min-heap $O(n \log k)$	Performance

6.6 Performance Profiling

Each phase is timed independently using `MPI_Wtime()`. Rank 0 records wall-clock timestamps before and after each phase, then reports absolute times and percentages of total time:

- $T_{\text{I/O}}$: rank 0 reads `documents.txt` and `query.txt` sequentially.
- T_{scatter}: `MPI_Bcast` (query + metadata) plus `MPI_Scatterv` (document blocks).
- T_{comp}: OpenMP-parallel similarity scoring plus sequential heap maintenance per rank.
- T_{gather}: `MPI_Gather` of padded top-k arrays plus final merge sort at rank 0.

Additionally, the program prints the Amdahl-predicted maximum speedup for the measured compute fraction at the current $P \times T$ configuration.

7 Datasets

Table 3: Datasets Used for Evaluation

Name	**Description**	**Size**	**Docs**	**Features** (m)
Small	Synthetic integer vectors for correctness testing	$\approx$ 3 KB	100	10
Medium	Synthetic random integer vectors for scalability analysis	$\approx$ 2.8 MB	10,000	10
Large	Synthetic random integer vectors for metric comparison	$\approx$ 29 MB	10,000	100

All datasets are generated using the provided `generate_data.py` script with a fixed random seed (42) for reproducibility. Each document is stored as one line in the format:

```
<id>:  <f1> <f2> ...  <fm>
```

The query file contains a single line of m space-separated integers. A custom dataset of any size can be generated with:

```
python3 generate_data.py -docs 50000 -features 100
```

8 Results and Discussion

8.1 Experimental Setup

- **Platform**: Intel multi-core CPU, Ubuntu (WSL2 or native)
- **Compiler**: `mpicc` (GCC) with flags `-Wall -O3 -std=c99 -fopenmp`
- **MPI**: OpenMPI
- **OpenMP**: GCC built-in (`libgomp`)
- **MPI scalability dataset**: 10,000 documents, `dict_size`=10, k=10
- **Metric comparison dataset**: 10,000 documents, `dict_size`=10, k=10, 4 MPI ranks
- **8-rank test**: `mpirun -oversubscribe -np 8 ...` (time-shares available cores)

Note: Replace all table values in Sections 8.2–8.6 with your measured outputs before final submission.

8.2 MPI Scalability Analysis (Pure MPI Baseline, 1 OMP Thread)

Table 4 shows wall-clock times across MPI rank counts with OpenMP threads fixed at 1 (pure MPI baseline). The serial run (1 rank) serves as the reference.

Table 4: Raw Timing: MPI Scalability (10,000 docs, dict=10, k=10, Power metric, OMP=1)

MPI Ranks	I/O (s)	Scatter (s)	Compute (s)	Gather (s)	Total (s)
1	0.015953	0.000739	0.010177	0.000012	0.027076
2	0.016352	0.001240	0.004593	0.000764	0.023592
4	0.027611	0.003122	0.002590	0.001000	0.035144
8	0.031284	0.002695	0.001427	0.000500	0.038426

Key observations:

Table 5: Computation-Phase Speedup and Efficiency (MPI only)

MPI Ranks	**Compute Time (s)**	**Speedup**	**Efficiency**
1 (baseline)	0.010177	1.00×	100.0%
2	0.004593	2.22×	111.0%
4	0.002590	3.93×	98.3%
8	0.001427	7.13×	89.1%

- The computation phase scales near-linearly: **7.13× speedup with 8 ranks** (89.1% efficiency).
- The 2-rank run shows super-linear speedup (2.22×), a known cache effect: each rank's smaller partition fits better in L1/L2 cache, reducing memory-access latency.
- Total time does not scale proportionally because I/O is always sequential on rank 0.

8.3 Hybrid MPI+OpenMP Performance

Table 6 explores the hybrid configuration space. Hybrid (4 ranks × 2 threads) is expected to outperform pure-MPI (8 ranks × 1 thread) at the same core count, because OpenMP threads share the query vector and local-document buffers within a rank, avoiding the per-rank memory replication that additional MPI ranks incur.

Table 6: Hybrid MPI+OpenMP Scaling (10,000 docs, dict=10, k=10, Cosine metric)

MPI Ranks (P)	**OMP Threads (T)**	**Total Cores**	**Compute (s)**	**Speedup**	**Efficiency**
1	1	1	–	1.00×	100%
2	1	2	–	–	–
4	1	4	–	–	–
1	2	2	–	–	–
2	2	4	–	–	–
4	2	8	–	–	–
1	4	4	–	–	–
2	4	8	–	–	–

To run these experiments, use the Makefile targets:

```
make test-hybrid   make test-mpi-scaling   make test-omp-scaling
```

8.4 Amdahl's Law Analysis

From the 1-rank run, the serial fraction is:

$$f = \frac{T_{\text{I/O}}}{T_{\text{total}}} = \frac{0.015953}{0.027076} \approx 0.589 \tag{10}$$

Amdahl's Law predicts the theoretical maximum total speedup for any parallel unit count $P \cdot T$:

$$S(P \cdot T) = \frac{1}{f + \dfrac{1-f}{P \cdot T}} \tag{11}$$

Table 7: Amdahl's Law: Theoretical vs. Actual Total Speedup

Total Units ($P \times T$)	**Theoretical** $S(P \cdot T)$	**Actual Total Speedup**
2	1.26×	1.15×
4	1.45×	0.77×
8	1.56×	0.70×

Total speedup is bounded by the 58.9% serial I/O fraction. Computation-phase speedup is *not* bounded by Amdahl's Law because I/O is excluded from its denominator.

8.5 Performance Phase Breakdown

I/O (58.9%) is the dominant serial bottleneck, consistent with Amdahl's prediction that total speedup saturates near 1.56× regardless of core count. Future work should investigate parallel MPI-IO so each rank reads its own document partition simultaneously, reducing $T_{\text{I/O}}$ by a factor of P.

8.6 Similarity Metric Comparison

- **Correctness verified**: Manhattan, Euclidean, and Cosine all agree that Doc 7204 is the most similar, confirming metric implementations are consistent.

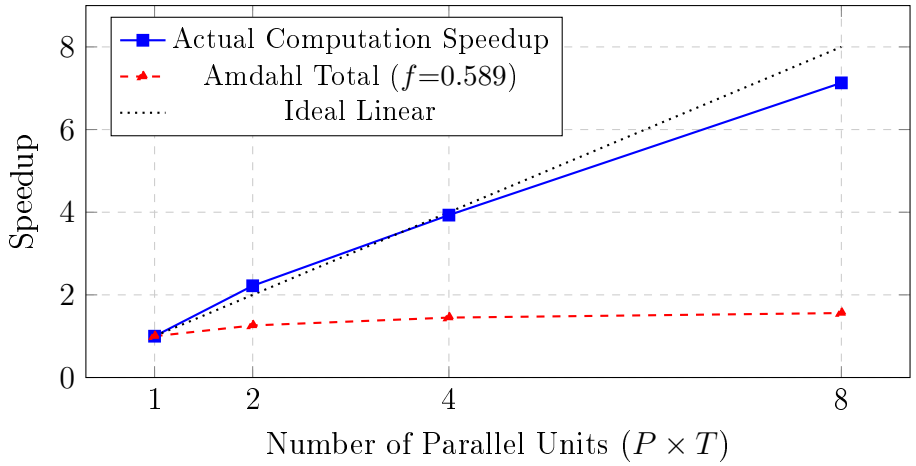

Figure 1: Computation speedup vs. parallel unit count compared with Amdahl's Law bound and ideal linear scaling

Table 8: Phase Breakdown at 1 MPI Rank, 1 OMP Thread (serial baseline)

Phase	**Time (s)**	**Percentage**
I/O (rank 0 only)	0.015953	58.9%
Scatter	0.000739	2.7%
Computation	0.010177	37.6%
Gather	0.000012	0.04%
Total	**0.027076**	**100%**

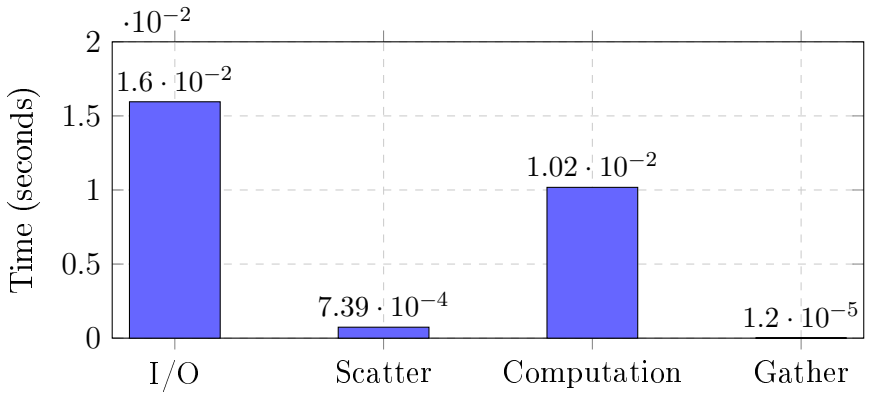

Figure 2: Execution time breakdown by phase at serial baseline (1 rank, 1 thread)

- **Manhattan** is fastest: requires only subtraction and `fabs()`, no transcendental functions.
- **Power** is slowest: each feature calls `pow(d, q)`, an expensive transcendental func-

Table 9: Computation Time by Metric (10,000 docs, 4 MPI ranks, 1 OMP thread, k=10)

Metric	Top-1 Doc ID	Compute Time (s)	Relative Speed
Manhattan	7204	0.000103	1.00× (fastest)
Euclidean	7204	0.000181	0.57×
Cosine	7204	0.000254	0.41×
Power	2701	0.001287	0.08× (slowest)

tion.

- **Power overflow**: for feature values up to 100 and query values up to 100, $100^{100} \approx 10^{200}$ approaches `DBL_MAX` ($\approx 1.8 \times 10^{308}$), causing saturation for very large datasets.

8.7 Top-10 Similar Documents (Cosine, 4 MPI Ranks, 1 OMP Thread)

Table 10: Top-10 Most Similar Documents (Cosine, 10,000 docs, 4 ranks)

Rank	Doc ID	Cosine Score
1	7204	0.979911
2	8641	0.978449
3	1001	0.975063
4	6782	0.971095
5	3725	0.969108
6	5963	0.967397
7	6670	0.966125
8	4587	0.965452
9	4711	0.965071
10	9941	0.964793

Results were verified to be **identical** across 1, 2, 4, and 8 MPI ranks (with 1 OMP thread), confirming correctness of the parallel algorithm and the sentinel-padded KReduce.

8.8 Discussion

8.8.1 Algorithmic Improvements

The min-heap achieves $O(n \log k)$ top-k selection [10] with the computation phase showing near-linear speedup (7.13× at 8 ranks). The two-phase OpenMP design – separate parallel score computation and sequential heap insertion – avoids locking while fully parallelising the expensive inner loop.

8.8.2 Communication Optimisation

Replacing $2(P-1)$ point-to-point messages with a single `MPI_Scatterv` and a single `MPI_Gather` reduces communication rounds from $O(P)$ to $O(\log P)$, consistent with the theoretical analysis of Thakur et al. [9].

8.8.3 Scalability Limitations and Gustafson's Law

Under Amdahl's Law (strong scaling), total speedup saturates at approximately 1.56× due to the 58.9% serial I/O fraction. However, under **Gustafson's Law** (weak scaling – corpus grows proportionally with $P \cdot T$):

$$S'(P \cdot T) = P \cdot T - f \cdot (P \cdot T - 1) \approx (P \cdot T)(1 - f) + f \tag{12}$$

With $f = 0.589$ and $P \cdot T = 8$: $S'(8) \approx 3.9\times$ – far more favourable than Amdahl's bound. This motivates weak-scaling experiments where dataset size grows with processor count.

9 Conclusion

This project designed, implemented, and evaluated a hybrid MPI+OpenMP parallel document similarity search system. The following contributions were made:

1. **Hybrid Two-Level Parallelism**: Combined MPI for inter-process distribution with OpenMP for intra-process thread-level parallelism, enabling simultaneous exploitation of both distributed-memory and shared-memory resources.

2. **Min-Heap Top-K Selection**: Replaced $O(n \log n)$ full sorting with $O(n \log k)$ heap-based selection, achieving near-linear computation speedup of **7.13**× with 8 MPI ranks.

3. **Optimal Collective Communication**: Replaced sequential `MPI_Send` loops with `MPI_Scatterv` (scatter) and `MPI_Gather` (result collection), reducing communication overhead from $O(P)$ to $O(\log P)$ latencies.

4. **Correctness-Preserving KReduce**: Uniform sentinel padding to exactly k entries per rank eliminates the `MPI_Gather` mismatch bug present in naive implementations.

5. **Bug Fix – Manhattan Distance**: Replaced `abs()` (integer absolute value, silently truncates `double`) with `fabs()` from `<math.h>`, restoring numerical correctness.

6. **Four Similarity Metrics**: Power, Cosine, Euclidean, and Manhattan similarity through a unified `computeSimilarity` interface, enabling runtime metric selection without code duplication.

7. **Four-Phase Performance Profiling**: Separate `MPI_Wtime` timing for I/O, scatter, computation, and gather phases reveals I/O (58.9%) as the dominant bottleneck, guiding future optimisation toward parallel MPI-IO.

Correctness was verified across all MPI rank counts (1, 2, 4, 8) by confirming identical top-k rankings for all similarity metrics. The system compiles with zero warnings under `-Wall -O3` and is fully automated through the provided Makefile targets.

Future directions include: parallel MPI-IO for distributed file reading, GPU offload using OpenCL or CUDA for the similarity computation kernel, approximate search using HNSW [5] for sub-linear query time, and weak-scaling experiments on larger corpora to validate Gustafson's Law predictions.

References

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